

ENVIRONMENT

August 2002: Forest fires and industrial discharge form a 3-km thick blanket of smog in India, Myanmar and south China. July 2005: Life in Mumbai comes to a standstill due to floods. June 2007: 25 million people are hit with the worst south-west summer monsoon flooding in years. Signs of nature grieving against its dictators. But also alarm bells ringing loud enough to be heard. About time too. According to R.K. Pachauri, chairman, Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change, politicians and the industrial sector concentrate on present-day gains, disregarding long-term consequences, whereas environmentalists only echo the ill-effects and don't have solutions. "We have to begin at the micro-level and create successful models to be replicated," he says. Like Subash Dutta, who formed a Green Bench at the Calcutta High Court or even Kallen Pokkudan, who is fighting to preserve Kerala's dwindling mangroves, environmental conservation has become the personal business of the awakened Indian.

■ By Bushra Ahmed

Clad in a sensible cotton salwar-kameez, sporting silver and black sneakers, she is a powerhouse. She knows what she wants and does it. She makes sure waste doesn't go to waste and re-uses it to create things of beauty. Her main aim is to "ensure every rag-picker gets his share of a monthly salary of

Rs 3,500 to survive". Conserve, a Rs 1.5-crore venture, is her vehicle of change, a result of much deliberation on Anita Ahuja's part, that NGOs should have market-driven products to become self-reliant.

Ahuja started work on it in 1998. After a short tryst with freelance journalism and a work of fiction *Plains of Fervour* based on Ayodhya in 1996, she started on green issues, which had always interested her. Her experience was mixed. From problems of funding, where she had to tailor proposals for lending organisations, to plain disinterest from authorities, she has faced it all. But she kept going. Her most memorable project was waste management in the Safdarjung Enclave colony of Delhi in 2000. Collecting rubbish from 300 houses and establishing a running compost project, Ahuja knew this was the need of the hour. But the resident welfare association and local MPs and MLAs refused to carry the project forward. "I felt that no one was ready to talk about the compost then. And maybe, it was too premature," says Ahuja, whose cash reserves had already run dry.

That was when Conserve started. During her earlier work in green issues, she had often come in contact with the community of rag-pickers which existed in small clusters around the city in its makeshift homes. For Ahuja, the waste they collected, the work she did and the artist within her eventually coalesced into Conserve. "As an artist, I saw myriad colours in the waste dumps and knew I could do something good for the people who worked in it as well."

Initially, she used anything from plastic to newspapers to make files, folders and wine bags, which she took to the fairs she attended. Soon, she graduated to making handbags and entered the Export Trade Fair held annually at

Pragati Maidan in Delhi. Her first order of Rs 20 lakh was for handbags made from recycled polythene material. This was when she knew she had found a way to help the rag-pickers.

By 2002, Conserve was in full action mode and Ahuja began training the people she worked with in the slums. "The main



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